

General Knowledge

Indian Geography

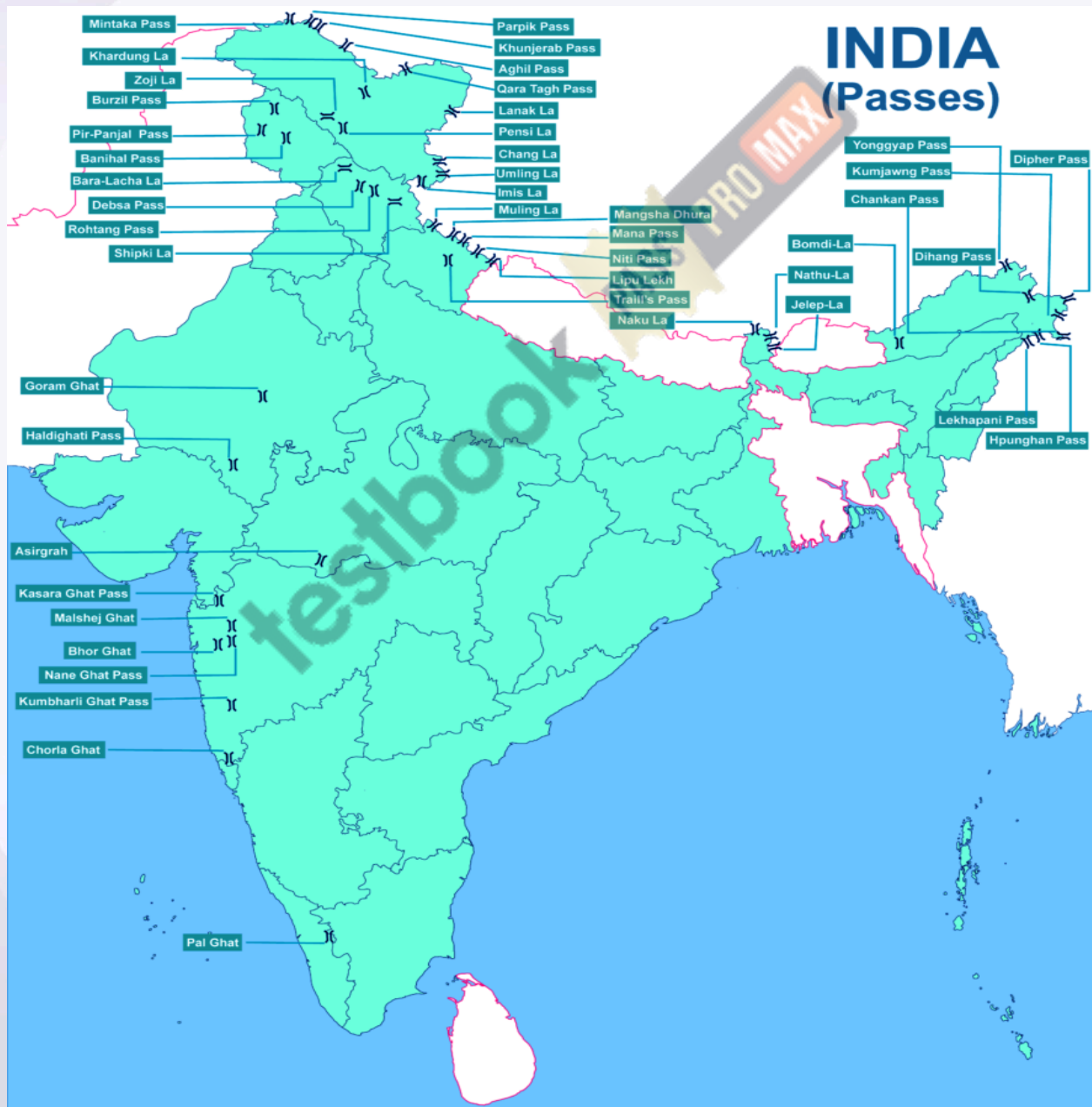
STUDY NOTES

Important Mountains Passes



Important Mountains Passes

A **mountain pass** is a pathway that traverses or cuts through a **mountain range**, typically found near the **headwaters** of rivers fed by **rain** or **snowmelt**. These formations can arise due to **mountain-building processes**, **glacial activity**, or **erosion** from **precipitation**. At **lower elevations**, such paths are called **hill passes**. While most pass summits are **flat** and resemble a **saddle**, their size can vary widely—from **narrow, high peaks** to **broad valleys** stretching for miles. A pass doesn't have to be completely flat but must be significantly **lower in elevation** compared to the surrounding **mountains**.



Major Mountain Passes in Leh-Ladakh

- 1. Chang La**
 - Connects **Leh** to **Pangong Lake**.
 - Elevation: **17,590 feet**.
 - **The Defence Research and Development Organization (DRDO)** station is nearby.
 - Visitors are advised to limit time due to **low oxygen levels**.
- 2. Bara-Lacha La Pass**
 - Part of the **Himalayan Zaskar Range**, connecting **Lahaul** and **Ladakh**.
 - Known as the "**Gateway to Ladakh**".
 - Historically significant as a **trading route**.
- 3. Khardung La Pass**
 - Gateway to **Nubra Valley**.
 - Managed by the **Border Roads Organization**.
 - Vital for supply transport to the **Siachen Glacier**.
- 4. Imis La**
 - Links **Ladakh** with **Tibet**.
 - Opens the way to the **Hanle Valley**, significant for **Buddhism**.
- 5. Zoji La Pass**
 - Located in **Dras**, connecting:
 - **Kashmir Valley (west)**,
 - **Indus Valley (east)**, and
 - **Suru Valley (northeast)**.
 - Construction of the **Zoji La Tunnel** began in 2020 to improve accessibility.
- 6. Tanglang La Pass**
 - Elevation: **17,480 feet (5,328 meters)**.
 - Connects **Debring** with **Gya**.

Major Mountain Passes in Jammu and Kashmir

- 1. Karakoram Pass**
 - Connects **India** and **China** in the **Karakoram Range**.
 - Historically vital for **travellers and trade**.
 - Features **harsh, desolate terrain**.
- 2. Pir Panjal Pass**
 - Links to **Kashmir Valley** with **Rajouri**.
 - Hosts the historic **Mughal Road**.
- 3. Banihal Pass**
 - Located on the **Jammu-Srinagar** route; now bypassed by the **Jawahar Tunnel**.
 - Near the **Zaban Glacier**.

4. Burzail Pass

- Connects **Astore Valley** (Kashmir) with the **Deosai Plains** (Ladakh).

5. Pensi La

- Links **Kashmir** to **Kargil** across the **Himalayas**.
-

Major Mountain Passes in Himachal Pradesh

1. Shipki La

- Connects **Kinnaur** (India) and **Tibet**.
- Used for **India-Tibet trade**, but restricted for non-residents.

2. Rohtang Pass

- Connects **Kullu Valley** with **Lahaul-Spiti**.
- Busy due to its short accessibility window from **May to October**.

3. Bara-Lacha La

- Passes the **Zaskar Range**, connecting **Lahaul** with **Leh**.

4. Debsa Pass

- Connects **Kullu** and **Spiti**.
 - Discovered by mountaineer **Joydeep Sircar** in 1995.
-

Major Mountain Passes in Uttarakhand

1. Mana Pass

- Links **Mana** (Uttarakhand) to **Tibet**.
- Part of the **Nanda Devi Biosphere Reserve**.
- Elevation: **18,748 feet**.

2. Niti Pass

- Previously a key route between **Tibet** and **India**, closed since **1962**.

3. Lipu Lekh

- Tri-junction of **India**, **Tibet**, and **Nepal**.
- Important for the **Manasarovar Yatra** and trade with **China**.

4. Traill's Pass

- Connects **Pindari Glacier** and **Milam Valleys**.
- Extremely **steep and challenging**.

5. Mangsha Dhura

- Significant for the **Manasarovar Yatra**, connecting Uttarakhand to Tibet.

6. Muling La

- Seasonal pass in the **Great Himalayas**, north of Gangotri.
-

Major Mountain Passes in the North Eastern States

1. **Nathu La**
 - Connects **Sikkim** with **Tibet**.
 - A meeting point for **Indian** and **Chinese troops**.
2. **Bom Di La**
 - Connects **Arunachal Pradesh** with **Tibet (Lhasa)**.
3. **Jelep La**
 - The trade route between **Sikkim** and **Tibet** closed post-1962.
4. **Diphu Pass**
 - Lies on the **MacMohan Line**, marking boundaries of **India, China, and Myanmar**.
5. **Pangsau Pass**
 - It connects **Arunachal Pradesh** with **Myanmar**, which is near the **Assam plains**.

Major Mountain Passes in the Western Ghats

1. **Bhor Ghat**
 - Links **Palasdari** and **Khandala**, located in **Maharashtra**.
2. **Thal Ghat**
 - Lies on the **Mumbai-Nashik Road**, connecting **Kalyan** and **Kasara**.
3. **Palakkad Ghat (Gap)**
 - Connects **Tamil Nadu** and **Kerala** through the **Nilgiri Hills**.
4. **Shencottah Gap**
 - Links **Madurai (Tamil Nadu)** and **Kottayam (Kerala)**.

The table below presents the important passes in India with their details:

Name of the Pass	Description
Nathu La Pass	Located in Sikkim, on the India-China border, reopened in 2006. A part of the ancient Silk Route and one of the trading posts between India and China.
Shipki La Pass	Located through Sutlej Gorge, connecting Himachal Pradesh with Tibet. India's third border post for trade with China, after Lipu Lekh and Nathula Pass.
Jelep La Pass	Passes through the Chumbi Valley, connecting Sikkim with Lhasa, the capital of Tibet.
Qara Tagh Pass	Located in the Karakoram Mountains, a subsidiary of the ancient Silk

	Route.
Umling La	The highest motorable pass in India connects Leh to Pangong Lake. Inaugurated in August 2021.
Khardung La	The second-highest motorable pass in India connects the Leh and Siachen glaciers. Closed in winter.
Thang La / Taglang La	Located in Ladakh, the second-highest motorable mountain pass in India.
Aghil Pass	Located north of Mount Godwin-Austen in the Karakoram, connects Ladakh with Xinjiang, China. Closed in winter.
Chang-La	High mountain pass in the Greater Himalayas, connects Ladakh with Tibet.
Lanak La	Located in Aksai Chin in Ladakh, connects Ladakh and Lhasa. China built a road to connect Xinjiang with Tibet.
Imis La	Pass with difficult terrain and steep slopes, closed in winter. Connects Ladakh with Tibet.
Bara-La / Bara-Lacha La	Situated on the National Highway in Jammu and Kashmir, connects Manali and Leh.
Traill's Pass	Located in Uttarakhand, connects Pindari Valley to Milam Valley. Steep and rugged terrain.
Lipu Lekh	Located in Uttarakhand, connects Uttarakhand with Tibet. An important border post for trade with China, used by pilgrims to Manasarovar.
Mana Pass	Located in the Greater Himalayas, connects Tibet with Uttarakhand. Snow-covered for six months during winter.
Mangsha Dhura Pass	Located in the Kuthi Valley, connects Uttarakhand with Tibet. Known for landslides, used by pilgrims to Manasarovar.
Muling La	Located north of Gangotri, connects Uttarakhand with Tibet. A seasonal pass, snow-covered in winter.
Niti Pass	Connects Uttarakhand with Tibet. Snow-covered during winter.
Debsa Pass	Joins Spiti Valley and Parvati Valley, a high mountain pass between Kullu and Spiti in Himachal Pradesh. A bypass route for Pin-Parvati Pass.
Rohtang Pass	Located in Himachal Pradesh, connects Kullu, Spiti, and Lahul.
Bomdi-La	Located in Arunachal Pradesh, connects Arunachal Pradesh with Lhasa, Tibet. Located east of Bhutan.
Dihang Pass	Located in Arunachal Pradesh, connects Arunachal Pradesh with Mandalay, Myanmar, at an elevation of more than 4000 m.

Diphu Pass	Located in Arunachal Pradesh, connects the disputed tripoint borders of India, China, and Myanmar. Strategic for eastern Arunachal Pradesh.
Pangsau Pass	Located in Arunachal Pradesh, connects Arunachal Pradesh with Myanmar. At an elevation of 3,727 ft. Offers one of the easiest routes into Myanmar.
Banihal Pass (Jawahar Tunnel)	Located in Jammu and Kashmir, connects Banihal with Qazigund, situated in the Pir-Panjal Range.
Zoji La	Connects Srinagar with Kargil and Leh. The Border Roads Organization clears and maintains the road, especially in winter.
Burzail Pass	Connects Astore Valley in Kashmir with Deosai Plains in Ladakh.
Pensi La	Connects Kashmir valley with Kargil, situated in the Greater Himalayas.
Pir-Panjal Pass	Traditional pass from Jammu to Srinagar. Closed after the partition. Provides the shortest access to Kashmir valley from Jammu.
Shencottah Gap	Located in the Western Ghats, connects Madurai (Tamil Nadu) with Kottayam (Kerala). Known for rail and road routes passing through it.
Bhor Ghat	Located between Palasdari and Khandala in Maharashtra. Important railway and road route, historically used by the Satavahana to connect ports in Konkan with the Deccan plateau.
Thal Ghat	Located near Kasara in Maharashtra, connects Mumbai and Nashik. Known for steep railway gradients.
Pal Ghat	Located between Nilgiri Hills (north) and Anaimalai Hills (south), connects Coimbatore (Tamil Nadu) with Palakkad (Kerala).